

CONTACT	Minda Zhao Email : mindazhao@gatech.edu Website : https://minda-zhao.github.io/Personal-Website Address : Room 1111, George Tower, 55 5th St NW, Atlanta, GA 30332		
EDUCATION	● Georgia Institute of Technology (Georgia Tech) Atlanta, GA <i>Ph.D. student in Operations Research</i> 2022 - 2027 (Expected) – Advisor : Prof. Xin Chen ● University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign (UIUC) Champaign, IL <i>Ph.D. student in Industrial Engineering</i> 2021 - 2022 – Transferred to Georgia Institute of Technology. ● University of Chicago (UChicago) Chicago, IL <i>M.S. in Computational and Applied Mathematics</i> 2019 - 2020 – Advisor : Prof. Lek-Heng Lim ● Sun Yat-sen University (SYSU) Guangzhou, China <i>B.S. in Information and Computing Science</i> 2015 - 2019		
RESEARCH INTEREST	Methodology : Stochastic Programming, Nonconvex Optimization. Application : Operations Models, Optimal Control, Reinforcement Learning.		
PREPRINTS	1. Benign Nonconvex Landscape for Policy Optimization : Infinite-Horizon Discounted MDPs with General State and Action. [SSRN] Xin Chen, Minda Zhao (alphabetical order) – Submitted. 2. Hidden Convexity in Queueing Models. [ArXiv] [SSRN] Xin Chen, Linwei Xin, Minda Zhao (alphabetical order) – Under minor revision at <i>Operations Research</i>. – Selected to present at the 2026 Next-Gen Scholar Symposium. 3. A Simple Solution to Improving Human Supervision of Algorithms : Evidence from Smart Vending. [SSRN] Minda Zhao, Brian Han, Xin Chen, Tao Zhu – Under major revision at <i>Manufacturing & Service Operations Management</i>. – Finalist, INFORMS BOM Section Best Working Paper Competition, 2026. – Winner, POMS College of BOM Junior Scholar Paper Competition, 2026. – Selected as an oral presentation at MSOM Supply Chain SIG 2025. – Third Place, CSAMSE Practice Award 2024. 4. Landscape of Policy Optimization for Finite Horizon MDPs with General State and Action. [ArXiv] Xin Chen, Yifan Hu, Minda Zhao (alphabetical order) – Under Reject & Resubmit at <i>Operations Research</i>, re-submitted. – Extended abstract accepted by NeurIPS 2025 ML×OR Workshop.		
PUBLICATIONS	1. Stochastic Steffensen Method. [Link] Minda Zhao, Zehua Lai, Lek-Heng Lim. 2024 <i>Computational Optimization and Applications</i>, pp.1-32.		
HONORS AND AWARDS	● Finalist, INFORMS BOM Section Best Working Paper Competition ● Winner, POMS College of BOM Junior Scholar Paper Competition ● Shabbir Ahmed PhD Fellowship for Excellence in Research – Awarded annually to one Ph.D. student (co-winner) in ISyE for research in optimization ● Third Place, CSAMSE Practice Award ● NCCR Automation Fellowship, Switzerland (CHF 18,000 ; approx. US \$22,000) ● Hansen Fellowship, UIUC	2026 2026 2025 2024 2024 2021	

TEACHING	• Instructor, Georgia Tech - ISyE 3103 Supply Chain Modeling : Logistics (undergraduate course) Summer 2026 • Teaching Assistant, Georgia Tech - ISyE 7682 Convexity (graduate course) Spring 2026 - ISyE 8803 Pricing and Revenue Management (graduate course) Spring 2023 • Guest Lecturer, Georgia Tech - ISyE 8803 Optimization and Learning in Operations (graduate course) Spring 2025
CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS	• Hidden Convexity in Queueing Models. - INFORMS RMP Conference, Ann Arbor, MI Jul 2026 - INFORMS IOS Conference, Atlanta, GA Mar 2026 - (Poster) Cornell Young Researchers Workshop, Ithaca, NY Oct 2025 • A Simple Solution to Improving Human Supervision of Algorithms : Evidence from Smart Vending. - Annual POMS Conference, Reno, NV May 2026 - INFORMS MSOM Conference, Supply Chain Management SIG, London, UK Jun 2025 - Conference on Digital Experimentation @ MIT, Boston, MA Oct 2024 • Landscape of Policy Optimization for Finite Horizon MDPs with General State and Action. - INFORMS MSOM Conference, Boston, MA Jul 2026 - INFORMS IOS Conference, Atlanta, GA Mar 2026 - (Poster) NeurIPS 2025 ML×OR Workshop, San Diego, CA Dec 2025 - INFORMS Annual Meeting, Atlanta, GA Oct 2025 - International Conference on Continuous Optimization, Los Angeles, CA Jul 2025 - INFORMS RMP Conference, New York, NY Jul 2025 - INFORMS APS Conference, Atlanta, GA Jun 2025 - INFORMS Annual Meeting, Seattle, WA Oct 2024 - (Poster) Cornell Young Researchers Workshop, Ithaca, NY Oct 2024 - Purdue Operations Conference, West Lafayette, IN Aug 2024 - INFORMS Annual Meeting, Phoenix, AZ Oct 2023
SERVICES	• Session Organization : - INFORMS Annual Meeting Nov 2026 Session : Inventory Management in Logistics : Policies, Learning, and Asymptotic Insights - International Conference on Continuous Optimization (ICCOPT 2025) Jul 2025 Session : Recent Advances in Optimization for MDPs and Stochastic Optimal Control • Reviewer : - <i>Operations Research, Management Science, Manufacturing & Service Operations Management, Naval Research Logistics, Computational Optimization and Applications</i>
INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE	• Shenzhen Fengyi Technology Co., Ltd. Shenzhen, China Research Scientist Intern Jul 2023 - Aug 2023 - Developed a new replenishment strategy, reducing annual inventory costs by \$1,000,000. • Cainiao Network Hangzhou, China Research Scientist Intern Jun 2021 – Oct 2021
REFERENCES	• Xin Chen (Professor) - Naveen Jindal School of Management, UT Dallas - Email : xin.chen@utdallas.edu • Linwei Xin (Associate Professor) - School of Operations Research and Information Engineering, Cornell University - Email : lx267@cornell.edu • Guanghai (George) Lan (A. Russell Chandler III Chair and Professor) - H. Milton Stewart School of Industrial and Systems Engineering, Georgia Tech - Email : george.lan@isye.gatech.edu